BOND RULES VETO SURVIVES VOTE

As racial tensions bubble over, Chicago aldermen fail to make it harder for Johnson to issue city debt. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

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ENDEAVOR, RUSH MOVE TO MERGE

If deal is approved, system will include 12 hospitals, 46,000 employees and more than 400 sites of care

By Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Two major Chicago-area hospital systems — Endeavor Health and Rush University System for Health — announced plans Wednesday to merge, a union that would create one of the largest health systems in Illinois.

If the merger goes through, all the system's hospitals would include "Rush" as part of their names, and the "Endeavor" name would eventually disappear.

Endeavor and Rush hope to close the deal in early 2027, pending regulatory approval. The combined system would include 12 hospitals, more than 46,000 employees and more than 400 sites of care.

The merger would allow Rush — which has three hospitals in Chicago, Aurora and Oak Park — to reach more patients in additional geographic areas, said Rush President and CEO Dr. Omar Lateef. He said he expects the merger would "dramatically improve care across the state of Illinois."

It would also allow the nine-hospital Endeavor system to take advantage of Rush University Medical Center's strong reputation as a premier academic medical institution.

Rush University Medical Center tied with Northwestern Memorial

See **MERGE** on Page A4

$1B

In the deal, Endeavor would put $1 billion from its endowment toward the new system's efforts, including $300 million to reduce healthcare disparities in the region.

WHAT'S NEXT?
The deal must still get approval from state and federal regulators, who may look at it with an eye toward whether it would reduce competition and increase prices.

ELECTION 2026 GOVERNOR

At forum, old themes emerge

Bailey, Pritzker tread little new ground in the race's only debate

By Rick Pearson and Dan Petrella
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The lone scheduled face-to-face meeting between the major-party candidates for Illinois governor was largely viewed as the biggest opportunity for poorly funded Republican challenger Darren Bailey to make his case for defeating Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker.

Instead, the chippy Tuesday night affair reverted to anticipated themes, with Bailey repeatedly attacking and interrupting Pritzker, while the governor countered by casting the Republican as a conservative extremist and a follower of President Donald Trump.

Bailey, a downstate farmer seeking to reverse his loss to Pritzker four years ago, sought to turn the governor's frequent invocations of Trump into a game. He said Pritzker was using the president as a diversion to avoid having to "own the failures and the problems of Illinois" and

See **GOVERNOR** on Page A5



Gov. JB Pritzker, left, and Republican challenger Darren Bailey prepare for their debate at WTTW-Ch. 11 on Tuesday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE**

KEEPING THE BEARS IN ILLINOIS? Pritzker said he expected lawmakers to act during the fall veto session on legislation to keep the Bears in Illinois, as the team considers an offer from Indiana's GOP-led government to move to Hammond. Bailey, however, contended Indiana Gov. Mike Braun had assured him the team was moving across the border.

ELECTION 2026 SCHOOL BOARD PRESIDENT

Watchdog says no 'actionable finding' of misconduct by Dominguez

By Alice Yin and Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Public Schools watchdog has concluded an investigation into school board president candidate Hilario Dominguez by determining "there is no actionable finding of sexual misconduct" by him, according to letters sent Wednesday to Dominguez and the woman who has accused him of wrongdoing.

CPS' Office of Student Protection and Title IX sent the notices to Dominguez and the woman at the center of the case, which was recently reopened by CPS Inspector General Philip Wagenknecht.

The OIG "determined that there is no actionable finding of sexual misconduct ... with respect to possible Chicago Public Schools

See **CPS** on Page A9



Chicago Board of Education presidential candidate Hilario Dominguez speaks in River North on Oct. 6. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ELECTION 2026 STATEWIDE RACES

Comptroller race key to Democrats' stronghold on constitutional offices

By Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois Democrats have held every statewide constitutional office since early 2019, and a sweep on Nov. 3 would extend that lock on state government to 12 years.

Along with the governor's race, voters will decide contests for attorney general, secretary of state, treasurer and comptroller. Only one of the five is an open seat — comptroller — as Democrat Susana Mendoza announced she is leaving after a decade in office to run for Chicago mayor next year.

Two candidates from opposite ends of the state are vying to replace her: Democratic state Rep. Margaret Croke of Chicago and Republican Bryan Drew, a lawyer from southern Illinois.

Drew, who ran unopposed in the Republican primary, acknowledged earlier this year that the office under Mendoza has paid the state's bills on time. But he said someone with differing viewpoints on public finance should hold the job for purposes of "checks and balances," since Democrats control every constitutional office.

Croke, who is endorsed by Gov. JB Pritzker, said she can be "fiscally responsible" while also "making sure I'm investing in our

See **STATEWIDE** on Page A2

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